The inverse of conductivity is called resistivity (ρ) [Refer section 2.2.1].

$$\rho = \frac{1}{\sigma} = \frac{m}{ne^2\tau} \qquad (2.13)$$

EXAMPLE 2.3

A copper wire of cross-sectional area 0.5 mm^2 carries a current of 0.2 A. If the free electron density of copper is 8.4×10^{28} m^{-3} then compute the drift velocity of free electrons.

Solution

The relation between drift velocity of electrons and current in a wire of cross-sectional area A is

$$v_d = \frac{I}{neA} = \frac{0.2}{8.4\times10^{28}\times1.6\times10^{-19}\times0.5\times10^{-6}}$$

$v_d = 0.03 \text{ x } 10^{-3} \text{ m s}^{-1}$

Note

Why current density is a vector but current is a scalar?

In general, the current I is defined as the scalar product of the current density and area vector in which the charges cross.

$$I = \vec{J} \cdot \vec{A}$$

The current I can be positive or negative depending on the choice of the unit vector normal to the surface area A.

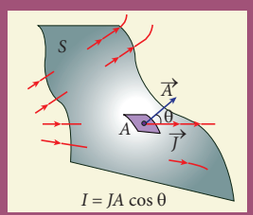


Figure 2.6 Current is a scalar

EXAMPLE 2.4

Determine the number of electrons flowing per second through a conductor, when a current of 32 A flows through it.

Solution

I = 32 A , t = 1 s

Charge of an electron, $e = 1.6 \times 10^{-19}$ C

The number of electrons flowing per second, n =?

$$I = \frac{q}{t} = \frac{ne}{t}$$

$$n = \frac{It}{e}$$

$$n = \frac{32\times1}{1.6\times10^{-19}C}$$

$n = 20 \times 10^{19} = 2 \times 10^{20}$ electrons

2.2 OHM'S LAW

The ohm's law can be derived from the equation J = σE. Consider a segment of wire of length l and cross sectional area A as shown in Figure 2.7.

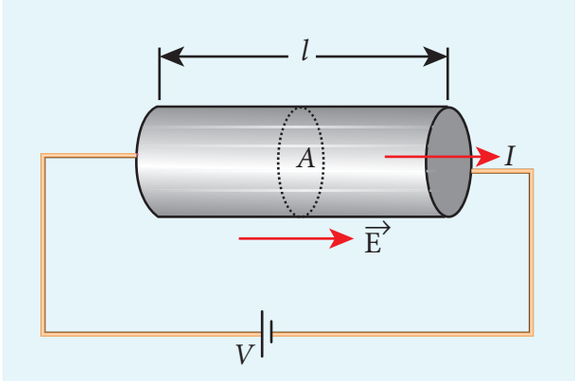


Figure 2.7 Current through the conductor